

Call to Action: The Great American Short Story

By **Laura Frame**

Is “The Great American Novel” a survival tool? Not technically, unless I need to defend myself by throwing it at someone. But an entertaining or effective story can act as a cautionary tale or a way to distribute information to an audience in a memorable, relatable way. As journalist Cody Delistraty, author of the article “The Psychological Comforts of Storytelling,” writes, “The theory is that if I tell you a story about how to survive, you’ll be more likely to actually survive than if I just give you the facts” (Delistraty). He explains that if someone tells you not to approach a tree because there’s a wild animal there, giving you those facts would be less effective than telling a story about his relative who was eaten by a big, scary thing by that tree. Since narratives engage emotions, they become more memorable than plain data. In the case of climate change science, the information is not necessarily memorable or engaging for non-scientists, prompting the emergence of climate fiction, a newer genre; cli fi uses storytelling to discuss the hazards of anthropogenic climate change and their effect on the lives of people and the environment. Cli fi identifies scientifically proven natural hazards of climate change such as extreme weather, disasters, species/habitat loss and others as well as hazards such as breakdowns in infrastructure and social systems, resource scarcity, illness/disease, and moral ambiguity. To Delistraty’s point, the science and awareness of climate change is more effectively distributed through stories that include the human condition than simply hard facts. One of the hazards that author Helen Simpson includes involves not just the human condition but specifically the female condition, as a mirror of the condition of our global environment or, “Mother Nature.” Simpson

uses her short story “Diary of an Interesting Year” to illustrate how our patriarchal society abuses both women and the environment, and the connection between the abuses.

In “Diary of an Interesting Year,” Simpson uses her nameless protagonist’s point of view to illustrate the impact of abuse on her and her closest friend. Different men perpetuate the abuse in successively abusive scenes, beginning with the women’s spouses and until the protagonist self harms for survival. An early diary entry describes the non violent but physically controlling behavior of her husband: “Another row with G. He blew my second candle out, he said one was enough. It wasn’t though. I couldn’t see to read anymore. He drives me mad—it’s like living with a policeman. It always was, even before the Collapse” (Simpson). Although the protagonist gives few brief snippets of their life pre-Collapse, one thing she uses her tiny supply of paper to note is G.’s casually domineering and dismissive behavior towards her; women often overlook, rationalize, and tolerate this type of behavior. The protagonist herself dismisses him as an “older man”; however, his policing is a clear display of power and although he uses no physical force against her, he blows out the candle. Simpson uses the candlelight to show a setting that lacks basic services. Additionally, it serves as a beacon of illumination and hope; her husband snuffs out half of this hope to exercise his assumed authority and lead the reader into a dimming world. Her friend Maia’s situation is more serious due to direct physical abuse. The protagonist gives brief but intense glimpses of Maia, including this entry: “I havered (mostly at the thought of coming between her and that throwback Martin—she had a new black eye, I didn’t ask)” (Simpson). Martin is clearly abusing his pregnant wife. This battering creates additional obstacles for Maia and her baby to survive the pregnancy. Simpson illustrates here how, whether the relationship is with women or the environment, men manufacture violence—thus amplifying hardship—even in situations where extra care is required. While we currently live in an

environment that is suffering from extreme weather and serious illnesses caused by excessive pollution, men continue their adoration of two-stroke engines for power tools and superfluous recreational vehicles rather than mitigate the pollution by mainstreaming alternatives or giving up the destructive hobbies. Simpson uses foreshadowing throughout the story by deepening the level of abuse against women as she introduces new characters. The protagonist describes potential sexual abuse by the climate refugees assigned to her home: “G. depressed. The four Spaniards are bigger than him, and he’s worried that the biggest one, Miguel, has his eye on me (with reason, I have to say)” (Simpson). The violent Spanish group of climate refugees occupying their home compels G. and the protagonist to fear sexual violence against her. Her description reveals a clear threat of rape - a violent crime that centers on power and control. Men commit rape because they can. Similar to the Spanish men is G.’s murderer, “M.” The diary writer describes his initial treatment of her after he kills her husband: “He’s turned everything else inside out (including me)” (Simpson). The marauder uses rape and violence to maintain power over the protagonist. Scarcity of resources caused by intense climate change in the story signals violent competition for available resources in general; M. acts in a more extreme way by killing, raping, and stockpiling supplies, mirroring the actions of people plundering the planet’s resources in order to stockpile for themselves. The protagonist notes M.’s casual view of her as another resource to be depleted: “If we run out of beans I think he might kill me for food. This one wouldn’t think twice. I’m just meat on legs to him.” Simpson intensifies the level of violence this time from rape to cannibalism, illustrating both a power play and the dark absurdity of the lengths men will go to in exploiting women. Ultimately, the diary writer resorts to self harm as a means of survival. She describes ending her pregnancy, likely unsurvivable for both her and the baby even under the best circumstances the story’s environment could offer: “Very bruised and

scratched after today. They used to throw themselves downstairs to get rid of it. The trouble is the gravel pit just wasn't deep enough, plus the bramble bushes kept breaking my fall" (Simpson). The protagonist risks her life and injures herself in an unsuccessful attempt to end her pregnancy for both her survival and the prevention of the baby's suffering and inevitable death shortly after birth. Although she is also motivated by self-preservation, this woman does not want to bring a baby into the world to suffer and die. Her penultimate entry is of her caring for the fetus' remains: "I've wrapped your remains in my good blue shirt; sorry I couldn't let you stay on board, but there's no future now for any baby above ground" (Simpson). Her self-induced abortion is directly caused by climate change. Giving birth is barely achievable in her world, practically devoid of food, sanitation, clean air and water yet full of disease; infant mortality is virtually guaranteed. The protagonist's vivid first-person descriptions both immerse the reader in her circumstances and amplify the climate-change fueled violence against her and Maia.

In *Borderlands of Science: How to Think Like a Scientist and Write Science Fiction*, Charles Sheffield presents his own definition of science fiction wherein actual science is a large land mass of factual information and the degree of fiction's scientific basis dictates its distance from this land mass into a body of water; fiction about science—with no speculation or predictions—has one's feet firmly on dry land and not touching any water, while science fiction rooted in science and containing predictions and speculation of future events bring one into the water until reaching the fantasy genre, which Sheffield notes is far out at sea, with land barely in sight. In terms of Sheffield's Metaphor, the world of Simpson's protagonist is somewhere in the water, at least in sight of land; it is not a direct parallel to our current world and we will not necessarily be eating each other by 2040, or at least that is my hope as I may be too old to put up a great fight

by then. But as with all cli fi, Simpson's vivid story has its roots in valid scientific data. Simpson uses the abuse against women, long associated with Mother Earth and Mother Nature, to symbolize the stress and abuse humans have perpetrated against our environment.

The exploitation of both women and our planet's environmental resources is centered around power; as both are viewed in popular stereotypes as birthers and nurturers, authority and power over both are forcibly taken by patriarchal figures. Women are historically more affected by climate change than men. A report from United Nations Women discusses gender inequality in climate change. This report notes the more severe impact climate change has on women than on men:

The adverse effects of drought, floods, hurricanes, extreme rainfall events and sea level rise are often felt more keenly by women than men as a result of systemic gender discrimination and societal expectations related to gender roles. These adverse effects have varied social, financial and economic dimensions. All submissions indicated that a complex interaction of social factors puts women and marginalized groups at greater risk of experiencing the adverse effects of climate change over a prolonged period (UN Women).

As global systemic gender inequality intersects with the effects of extreme weather, resource scarcity, environmental/ecosystem degradation, infrastructure degradation, and habitat loss, women are more at risk than men without the power to properly fight it. Globalization has connected commerce and communities to varying degrees although many rural women remain isolated and continue to lack

resources. Women can make some progress but with men still in the position of dominance, climate change will continue to affect women more harshly than men. The same UN Women article explains the increasing threat of women and girls affected by climate change in the future: “The Gender Snapshot 2024 report indicates that by 2050, climate change may push up to 158 million more women and girls into poverty (16 million more than the total number of men and boys). Even today, 47.8 million more women face food insecurity and hunger than men” (UN Women). By 2050, more women will still be pushed into poverty than men. Rural women are especially vulnerable; gender stereotypes and religion have a greater hold on rural communities, resulting in more responsibility for women to fulfill needs with fewer household resources, higher rates of domestic violence, less access to financial independence or control, mobility, training, and fewer resources for personal aid and care. Isolation is a key factor in perpetuating abuse against women; abusive men typically isolate their victims from their personal support systems while rural women, isolated by definition, have little in the way of support to begin with. When women unite to fight climate change, they are capable of effective mitigation or adaptation. UN Women describes a community of women taking the initiative to save their income and way of life:

“Take for example the ‘*conchera* women’ (shell women) of Tumaco, Colombia who, for generations, have been sustainably harvesting a mollusk called *piangu* for food and income. When they recognized that the destruction of local mangrove forests was destroying the *piangu*, they came together to create a programme to replant the trees. Not only will the

mangroves help preserve the local harvest and traditions, they'll also filter water, preserve coastlines and absorb carbon" (UN Women).

UN Women goes on to note that the women learned about business, finances and connecting with other women. The result is that engaged and empowered women can produce successful results, which should be no surprise as women's daily grind is often running from one fire to put out the next, especially in the case of rural and lower income women. The current global reality, however, is the patriarchal system that keeps men in control of resources. As men are stereotypically perceived as more qualified to control and manage resources, it is unconsciously understood that women are also resources due to birthing and, in many parts of the world, managing domestic work including food production, except where power comes into play. In professional kitchens, for example, power is once again at the forefront, and therefore men typically dominate professional and high-end kitchens. An article from *Economist Impact* recognizes the power grab: "The climate crisis, it is argued, is also borne out of a desire for power—power over the planet and the finite natural resources that provide comfort and convenience to billions. Climate change inevitably interacts with—and often exacerbates—issues related to gender and power" (*Economist Impact*). When power is at the core, men will always also be there, whatever the cost—even if we all must pay and even if we pay the ultimate price. Simpson takes climate change science and intersects it with gender inequality; she shows the

reader a vivid, memorable caricature of a woman fighting to survive men in a world that may not be able to.

In the way men have largely been "mining" women for offspring and resources that they find useful, then discarding women at "a certain age," they have also been mining the planet for its resources and destroying or discarding the rest for convenience. Journalist Joyce Chepkemai discusses the extractive industries' impact on our environment in her article "What Is the Environmental Impact of the Mining Industry?" Chepkemai describes the effect of mining activities on plant life and biodiversity:

Often, the worst effects of mining activities are observed after the mining process has ceased. The destruction or drastic modification of the pre-mined landscape can have a catastrophic impact on the biodiversity of that area. Mining leads to a massive habitat loss for a diversity of flora and fauna ranging from soil microorganisms to large mammals. Endemic species are most severely affected since even the slightest disruptions in their habitat can result in extinction or put them at high risk of being wiped out. Toxins released through mining can wipe out entire populations of sensitive species. (Chepkemai)

Men have long used women as resources, extracting offspring when needed or desired, and extracting skills or abilities. The result for women's bodies is not unlike what happens to our ecosystems; forced or obligate pregnancies can lead to many irreversible health crises, up to and including death. Damage to women's mental health is a separate hazard and can also be irreversible and lead to death..

Chepkemai also notes that even with remediation, the land around mines can take decades or longer to bounce back and some damage is irreversible. The same is true for women, who can have chronic or irreversible conditions from forced pregnancy, pregnancy complications, violence such as domestic violence and rape, among others. Some women may never bounce back. Extractive industries also include overarching patriarchal dominance. Environmental sociologist Nadie Suliman's article discusses the connection between the patriarchy and power in relation to extraction industries. Suliman writes, "Extractive industries and capitalistic governance systems have gone hand in hand with patriarchy and uneven distribution of power all over the world" (Suliman). Suliman later notes a high level of interconnectedness between the environmental, economic, social, and political in extractive industries, including the surrounding communities. Extractive industries have typically been dominated by men, mining the planet's resources for profit and maintaining a firm grip on the industry's resources and the profits in order to maintain general dominance. For example, within communities that surround extraction projects, there is a higher rate of domestic violence; at the executive level, men are protected by the glass ceiling they constructed. As toxic materials are used in the mining industry, toxic masculinity dominates men's attitudes towards women and the environment. Marketing professors Aaron Brough and James Wilkie have researched the connection between gender and environmental responsibility, noting that men feel "feminine" when taking even a minor eco-friendly action, such as using reusing bags. Brough and Wilkie explain the difference between men and women in terms of

environmental action: “Women have long surpassed men in the arena of environmental action; across age groups and countries, females tend to live a more eco-friendly lifestyle. Compared to men, women litter less, recycle more, and leave a smaller carbon footprint” (Brough & Wilkie). Although their work is more centered on personal habits, it parallels the professional arena. Clearly not all men are calculating power-hungry misogynists. However, the power-hungry misogynists have constructed a stigma around environmental responsibility, marking it as feminine, thus alienating the “average” man. Brough and Wilkie write about the stigma: “Our own research suggests an additional possibility: men may shun eco-friendly behavior because of what it conveys about their masculinity. It’s not that men don’t care about the environment. But they also tend to want to feel macho, and they worry that eco-friendly behaviors might brand them as feminine” (Brough & Wilkie). So while men might care about the environment, they don’t care enough to suffer the indignity of being labeled less masculine. Writer Joe McCarthy agrees, as he expresses in his article “Toxic Masculinity is Killing the Planet, Study Finds.” He cites Brough and Wilkie’s work in the article. McCarthy writes, “They found that men were more likely to rate environmentally friendly actions and products as feminine and choose environmentally harmful activities and products as a way to reassert their masculinity” (McCarthy). Men make conscious choices to display their perceived “masculinity” rather than do something that is less harmful to the environment, thus burying their heads in the social realm of perpetual adolescents who would rather be caught dead than be perceived as “uncool.” As adolescents tend to mock

those they consider geeks and nerds, so do grown men participating in *rolling coal*, a practice in which drivers of diesel trucks modify their engines and remove the emission controls in order to billow visually satisfying amounts of black smoke and fumes. Rolling *New York Times* reporter Hiroko Tabuchi discusses the practice in her article “‘Rolling Coal’ in Diesel Trucks, to Rebel and Provoke.”

Tabuchi explains the weaponization and typical targets of rolling coal:

“Depending on whom you ask, rolling coal is a juvenile prank, a health hazard, a stand against rampant environmentalism, a brazen show of American freedom.

Coal rollers’ frequent targets: walkers, joggers, cyclists, hybrid and Asian cars and even police officers. A popular bumper sticker reads “Prius Repellent”

(Tabuchi). Although the quoted opinions indicate more inconvenience and consternation than danger, rolling coal can pose immediate danger for those in, on, or around moving vehicles. Tabuchi’s article also relates an anecdote from a New Jersey legislator who was targeted and described the moment as “terrifying” while being enveloped in black smoke with no visibility. Largely a rural practice, rolling coal has become enough of a menace as to be outlawed in several states and it is a federal offense by definition as tampering with emissions systems is a federal offense. Besides direct human-to-human abuse, rolling coal is perhaps the most direct example of toxic masculinity towards environmentalism that further harms both the environment and women; the environmental damage impacts women’s health as well as perpetuating abusive behaviors. Additionally, since the Earth is symbolically viewed as “feminine” because of its fertility, nurturing, and sacrifice, which are also constructs that are associated with women, and women

have more of a tendency to care for the environment, women are the real targets of this knee jerk reaction to anyone who is considered a “treehugger.” Abuse, however, may only continue for so long before the victim either dies or takes measures against their abuser.

Although the protagonist in Simpson’s story murders the murderer and rids herself of that abuse, anthropogenic climate change is not so simple. Her fate is already clear amid resource scarcity, environmental toxins, disease, and breakdowns in civilization and infrastructure. In a world where even industrialized countries have no sanitation and no way for young lives to survive, she cannot survive long, nor can the planet without severe and largely fatal consequences for its own abusers, such as a new ice age. Where women like Simpson’s protagonist are stereotypically compared to the Earth as birthers and nurturers, men are compared to the Christian God, a possessor of power; somehow the one who holds the power in life is given more significance than the one who actually gives that life. Women are exploited for their bodies and skills as long as such skills coincide with the needs of the patriarchy; once women reach the age of physical infertility, they are cast off for younger versions, left like empty mines that no longer serve a purpose. “Diary of an Interesting Year” may not be a survival manual for women but the story effectively provides an entertaining dissemination of climate change hazards and shows the more profound effects of climate on women versus men. It is also a call to action. Simpson’s use of imagery, symbolism, and setting demonstrates the connection between the patriarchy’s abuse of both women and the planet and also shows

women's resilience and drive to survive. We can cast off our abusers and we can, despite dangerous and harmful behaviors from grown men, make progress in the fight to help our environment. The concheras of Colombia have made progress—without the pomp or fanfare that men frequently require—they made that progress for themselves, their communities, and the world. “Typical” men decry sentiment yet demonstrate excessive amounts of emotion when they perceive a threat to their power, their assumed freedoms, or their artificial masculinity. Unsung but undaunted women have been at the forefront of creativity and innovation and have done so while being virtually erased from history books despite their achievements. From Mary Shelley as the “mother” of science fiction to Katherine Johnson as a NASA mathematician to women like the Colombian concheras, women who may not be privileged or well educated but have the courage to seek and implement solutions to our climate crisis as the patriarchy typically refuses attempts at mitigation or actively seeks to perpetuate our crisis. Whether the patriarchy wins and sends us all into an ice age remains to be seen but like Simpson's protagonist, we women can fight for ourselves and the common good nonetheless. We will all die someday; Simpson's diary writer has her life cut short by climate change but it could have been cut short anyway under different circumstances. Any of our lives could be cut short but if we fight for improvement today, we might have a better tomorrow—or tomorrows.

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